

The Holy Cross: History, Significance, and Doctrine

By Dn Yonnas · Ethiopian Orthodox Tradition · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

How an instrument of Roman execution became the emblem of victory and salvation. The lesson tells of Queen Helena's finding of the True Cross and Constantine's vision, then shows the Cross in Orthodox dogma, in every sacrament, and in the daily life of the believer who signs themselves with it.

Lesson Objectives

- Tell the history of the finding of the True Cross by Queen Helena
- Explain what the Cross testifies about the Incarnation and our redemption
- Practice the sign of the Cross with understanding, not habit alone

Key Bible Verses

1 Corinthians 1:18 — "the message of the cross... to us who are being saved it is the power of God"

Galatians 6:14 — "God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord"

Colossians 2:14–15 — the handwriting against us nailed to the cross

Main Teaching Points

- The Cross was transformed from a tool of shame into the banner of salvation
- Queen Helena, in her eighties, journeyed to Jerusalem and uncovered the True Cross
- Constantine's vision — 'By this sign you will conquer' — marked the Cross's public triumph
- The Cross confirms the Creed: God truly became man and tasted death in the flesh
- Every sacrament is sealed with the Cross — baptismal water, the 36 crosses of Chrismation
- The sign of the Cross is spiritual protection, reminding the demons of their defeat at Golgotha

Key Terms

- **Meskel** — The Ethiopian feast of the Finding of the True Cross (Meskerem 17), celebrated with the Demera bonfire.
- **True Cross** — The actual cross of the Crucifixion, uncovered by Queen Helena in Jerusalem.
- **Sign of the Cross** — The believer's act of blessing and protection, confessing the Crucified in body and soul.
- **Golgotha** — The place of the Crucifixion — where the Devil was defeated.

Discussion & Reflection

- Why do Orthodox Christians make the sign of the Cross so often?
- What does the Cross prove about who Christ is and what He took on for us?
- How is Meskel (the Finding of the True Cross) celebrated in the Ethiopian Church?